

News Weekly

Prague zoo uses ice cubes to keep animals cool

At Prague Zoo, keepers used ice to help animals cope with a heat wave in Europe. Polar bears Aleut and Gregor enjoyed rolling in ice beds to stay cool as temperatures were expected to soar to 38°C (100.4°F). Zoo spokesperson Filip Mašek noted that this ice not only cools the bears but also enriches their lives. The zoo started providing ice two years ago in response to climate change and rising extreme temperatures. The bears, born 16 years ago in Nuremberg, Germany, have adapted to the European climate and seemed to enjoy the ice the most. Despite plans to supply ice in July and August, an early heat wave prompted the zoo to act sooner, with the Czech Republic experiencing its hottest day ever at 41.9°C (107.4°F) on June 28. Other animals like otters, elephants, and parrots also benefit from ice, while gorillas have been given ice with frozen fruits in the past. (ABC)



A forgotten fossil just revealed a new Triassic predator from 210 million years ago

Around 210 million years ago in present-day northern New Mexico, two jackal-sized early crocodile relatives perished together—likely in a flash flood—and were preserved at the Ghost Ranch fossil site. While *Hesperosuchus agilis* was an agile predator with a long snout built to hunt along rivers, a recently identified species found alongside it possessed a shorter, reinforced snout and stronger jaws for tackling larger prey.

Unearthed in 1948 and housed at the Yale Peabody Museum, the fossil remained unexamined for decades until Yale paleontologists used CT imaging to digitally separate the bones embedded in rock. The scans revealed distinct anatomical differences, confirming the specimen as a new species named *Eosporosuchus lacrimosa*.

This discovery provides rare evidence that early land-dwelling, dog-like crocodile ancestors were already diversifying into different ecological roles during the late Triassic period. It also highlights how modern imaging technology can unlock major scientific discoveries from existing museum collections. (Science Daily)



Adding water improves power of sodium-ion batteries

Sodium ion batteries, seen as a sustainable energy storage solution, may also aid in desalinating seawater. Research from the University of Surrey reveals that sodium-based battery materials, particularly nanostructured sodium vanadate hydrate (NVOH), perform better when their natural water content is retained. Contrary to the usual practice of removing water from battery materials, leaving it in enhances the material's charge capacity, speed, and longevity. The hydrated material almost doubles the charge capacity of typical sodium-ion materials. Additionally, NVOH works effectively in salt water, facilitating electrochemical desalination by removing sodium and chloride ions. This suggests a dual use for sodium-ion batteries: energy storage and saltwater desalination, potentially using seawater as an abundant electrolyte while producing fresh water.

(Science Daily)



Frozen pizza company issues 50th anniversary pizza with 50 toppings

Frozen pizzas have been a staple of freezers for decades, a useful option for a late-night snack or a contingency plan when you mess up the better dinner you were trying to cook.

And, for 50 years, one of the biggest players in the game has been Red Baron.

Now, the pizza brand is celebrating its 50th anniversary by dumping just about anything you can think of on top of a pie.

If your ideal pie just has a few pepperonis tossed on it, maybe Red Baron's 50th anniversary pizza isn't for you. (iStock) That's right, they're giving lucky winners the chance to go to town on a pizza with 50 toppings.

Baron von Richthofen himself could never have imagined when he was shot down during the Fourth Battle of Ypres that this would be his legacy...

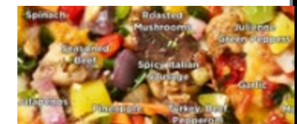
You can enter to win one on the company's website, but I don't even think I could name fifty pizza toppings. If someone locked me in a room and said I couldn't come out until I did, I'd probably get about 25 before I started panicking.

Red Baron is celebrating fifty years with a fifty-topping pizza. (iStock)

I'd get to arugula, and then I'd be like, "Sh--; someone has to have put rhubarb on pizza, right? RIGHT?!"

A lot is happening on that pie, maybe too much.

(Fox)



Rice bran compound may help ease irritable bowel symptoms

Research from Toho University reveals that ferulic acid (FA), a compound in rice bran and whole grains, can influence intestinal contractions by blocking voltage-dependent calcium channels. Led by Dr. Keisuke Obara, Dr. Kento Yoshioka, and Professor Yoshio Tanaka, the study found FA reduces contractions in guinea pig intestinal muscles, potentially helping manage disorders like irritable bowel syndrome (IBS) and inflammatory bowel disease (IBD). FA acts noncompetitively, affecting a shared contraction mechanism rather than blocking specific receptors. While FA may help regulate excessive muscle activity in diarrhea-predominant IBD, it could worsen symptoms for those with constipation-predominant IBS. The findings highlight FA's role as a natural modulator of gut motility, with implications for dietary approaches to intestinal disorders.



Jokes

Something you find is always in the last place you look.

Because once you find it you stop looking .

Phet



Peach Crostata

- For the pastry dough
 - 2 ½ cups all-purpose flour, plus more for dusting
 - 1 teaspoon granulated sugar
 - ½ teaspoon salt
 - 1 cup (2 sticks) cold unsalted butter, cut into ½-inch cubes
 - ½ cup ice water, add more if needed
- For the filling
 - 5-6 cups sliced ripe peaches (yellow peaches or nectarines), peeled if desired
 - ¼ cup granulated sugar (adjust based on peach sweetness)
 - 2 tablespoons all-purpose flour or cornstarch (for thickening)
 - 1 tablespoon fresh lemon juice
 - ½ teaspoon cinnamon (optional)
 - ¼ teaspoon nutmeg (optional)
 - 1 teaspoon almond extract (optional, enhances flavor)
 - 1 tablespoon unsalted butter, cut into small pieces for dotting
- For finishing
 - 1 large egg, beaten with 1 tablespoon water (for egg wash)
 - 2 tablespoons turbinado or coarse sugar for sprinkling
- Step 1: Prepare the dough
 - In a large bowl, whisk together flour, sugar, and salt.
 - Cut in the cold butter until the mixture resembles coarse crumbs with pea-sized chunks. These chunks create a flaky crust
 - Gradually add ice water, one tablespoon at a time, mixing until the dough just comes together. Avoid overmixing.
 - Form the dough into a disc, wrap in plastic wrap, and refrigerate for at least 30 minutes. Chilling firms the butter and relaxes the gluten for an easy-to-roll dough.
- Step 2: Prepare the peaches
 - Slice peaches into ½-inch wedges, and gently toss them with sugar, flour or cornstarch, lemon juice, cinnamon, nutmeg, and almond extract
 - If using very juicy peaches, sprinkle an extra tablespoon of sugar to reduce moisture that could make the crust soggy. Allow peaches to rest 10–15 min to draw out juices.
- Step 3: Assemble the crostata
 - Preheat oven to 375°F (190°C). Line a baking sheet with parchment paper.
 - Roll out chilled dough into a roughly 12–14-inch circle, ¼ inch thick. Transfer to the baking sheet.
 - Mound the peach filling in the center, leaving a 2-3 inch border. Arrange slices with slight overlap to create a rustic but even layer.
 - Fold the dough edges over the peaches, pleating as needed; the center should remain exposed
 - Dot the peaches with small butter pieces. Brush the folded crust generously with egg wash and sprinkle turbinado sugar over the edges.
- Step 4: Baking
 - Bake for 35–40 minutes until crust is golden brown and peaches are tender and bubbly. You may cover the crostata loosely with aluminum foil halfway through if edges brown too quickly
 - Allow to cool for 15–20 minutes to help the filling set before slicing.

	9	7		8	11	3	4		13			10	16	14	12
8		4	13	16			14	11	7		10			3	
10	1	11	16		2		12	3						8	9
14	2		3	7	10		15		8	16	5	11	6	1	4
2			11		8		6	13	16		12			4	5
	5	3	10	4		2		14		11	8	6	1		
	15		4	3	16	12		10		2	1	14	7		
6	12	13	1	11			10	7		5			3		16
7			14	12	6	4			10	13		16			8
13	4	6				16	11	12	3	8	9	1			
	16	9		2	5	10	13			14	6			7	3
		15	12		3	8	9	4	5	7	16	2	11	13	
5		16	15	6	14		3	8		10		13	12	9	
	8	2	9	10	4		16	6	12				14	5	
		1	7	13		5	8	16	11		3	4	2	6	10
	13					1			14		7	3	8		11